Sri Lanka has been the second favourite cricket team of most non-Lankan fans. The classic and the post-modern co-exist: for every Mahela Jayawardene there is a Sanath Jayasuriya, every Chaminda Vaas has a Lasith Malinga. Occasionally the two strains merge in one player, as with Kumar Sangakkara. Above all, there is Muttiah Muralitharan, claimer of the most international wickets, a bowler of intrigue and passion, of whom it might be said—adapting what an English writer said of Ranjitsinhji—that he never bowled a Christian ball in his life.

"Cricket is a fuller, funner, more enchanting game when Sri Lanka are firing," writes Nicholas Brookes in *An Island's Eleven*, adding, "and the island is a happier place too." You have to invent a word to describe Sri Lankan cricket. Sangakkara, their greatest batsman, said, "We must win playing the Sri Lankan way." By encouraging the mavericks, by accepting there is a way to bowl and bat that the classic textbooks don't mention, Sri Lankans have enriched the game. It is just over four decades since they made their Test debut, yet in that time they have won both white ball World Cups, and given the world some all-time greats.

Brookes, an Englishman living in Sri Lanka, brings to his history the fervour of the insider and the objectivity of the outsider. Cricket is not just about victories and defeats, runs scored and wickets taken. Sometimes a telling anecdote reveals more about a person than his batting average, and the book is packed with such anecdotes. The lack of an index in a book of this importance is galling, however.

Old-timers swear there could not be a better batsman than Mahadevan Sathasivam, an enchanter on and off the field. His double century at Chepauk is rated one of the best in India. Accused of murdering his wife, he was acquitted after a trial. From Sathasivam to Sangakkara through Arjuna Ranatunga and Aravinda de Silva is a line drawn with that special Sri Lankan mix of charm and hardiness.

SULTAN SEEMS ON THE VERGE OF REVEALING THINGS, BUT IT IS A MEMOIR OF JUSTIFICATION, NOT OF CONFESSION

As the nation went through cycles of disasters, natural and man-made, the cricketers gave its people something to hope for and be proud of.

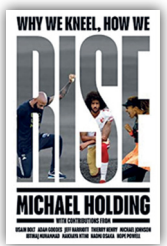
As with cricket in South Asia, the story is not just about the players, but intransigent and egoistical administrators too. Brookes describes this well, as does Wasim Akram in his second autobiography *Sultan: A Memoir*, this one ghosted by our finest cricket writer Gideon Haigh.

Although many stories from the first are repeated, we learn that the teenager Akram was a pigeon-fancier, that initially he didn't know what a yorker was (and when older and diagnosed with diabetes, he didn't know what 'sugar levels' was), that when the reverse swing was invented in Pakistan, it was called '*sibar*', which means 'the opposite way', that he was offered marijuana in the West Indies and after his career experimented with cocaine, and that a well-known bookie was a childhood friend and neighbour of his in Lahore.

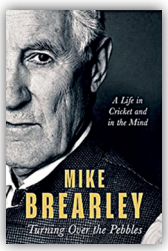
The grace and innocence of the first part of the book make way for a series of whines and complaints against teammates, officials and others (Imran Khan, his hero being an exception). Suspicion of teammates seems ingrained in Pakistan cricket and, as Akram says, "It is an environment that breeds temperamental, insecure, inconsistent teams."

Sultan seems on the verge of revealing things, but it is a memoir of justification, not of confession. Yet when both the lines and what's between them are read, there is a fuller picture of the man and his times. Akram doesn't go too deeply into things, but can thank his ghost for giving us a good read nevertheless. ■

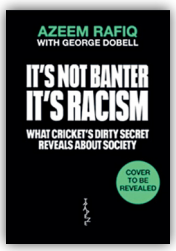
Suresh Menon



WHY WE KNEEL, HOW WE RISE
by Michael Holding
SIMON & SCHUSTER LTD



TURNING OVER THE PEBBLES
A Life in Cricket and in the Mind
by Mike Brearley
CONSTABLE



IT'S NOT BANTER, IT'S RACISM
by Azeem Rafiq
ORION PUBLISHING

that haven't been asked yet. As does *Hitting Against the Spin* (by Nathan Leamon and Ben Jones) with its graphs and figures and questions such as why Indians don't bat left-handed. You don't need to agree with everything, but they are thought-provoking and fun.

Unveiling Jazbaa: A History of Pakistan Women's Cricket by Aayush Puthran can be read as a social history of Pakistan as told through the story of women's cricket there. An important book, as is Michael Holding's *Why We Kneel, How We Rise*, the story of racism told by a great fast bowler who opened his heart out on television on the subject.

Two books I am looking forward to this year are *Turning Over the Pebbles: A Life in Cricket and in the Mind* by philosopher, psychoanalyst and a great captain, Mike Brearley, and *It's Not Banter, It's Racism* by Azeem Rafiq, Yorkshire's whistleblower on racism.